Wet Georgia Crawlspace


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Q. I have too much moisture in the crawlspace of my 1971 single-level brick home in west central Georgia. Can you recommend a method to lower the moisture level?

There is no plastic ground cover/barrier in the crawlspace. A 14-inch fan circulates air in the crawlspace (the fan is not located at a foundation vent; it just blows across the crawlspace). The foundation vents are open, including the screened crawlspace entry doors. There's no ground/rainwater flowing into the crawlspace. There are no roof gutters on the home.

The insulated ducts in the crawlspace have condensation on them; there is mold forming on floor joists in several places; and heavy moisture is collecting in several places on the floor joists and drips down. There's no sign of standing water in the crawlspace, including none inside of the foundation wall, but the ground there is damp, especially along the inside foundation wall. The outside air was very humid last summer and temperatures have been in the mid-high 90s.

Any information you could share would be greatly appreciated.

Mickey Holloway
Ellaville, Georgia

A. Mickey, it sounds like you already know what your problem is and what is contributing to it. You need to keep moisture out of your crawlspace, particularly if you are going to put cold A/C ducts down there. If it is difficult and/or expensive to move the A/C ducts, here's what you need to do:

Cover the ground with a vapor barrier. A 6-mil poly from your local hardware store is fine for this and will make it much nicer every time you (or an electrician/plumber/cable guy) have go into the crawlspace.

Close all the crawlspace vents.

Stop blowing humid air into the crawlspace with a fan.

Instead, blow (drier, conditioned) air from your house to the crawlspace. You only need a small fan for this once you have sealed all the crawlspace vents. Something like 100 CFM would be plenty.

Add gutters. Get the water from the downspouts away from the foundation. The ground should slope away from the foundation as well.

The above may not totally cure your problem if you have rain leaks or groundwater issues, but it will deal with the outdoor air as a moisture source.